

Speaking Well of God

A complete rebuild of the listening, reading, searching and multilingual experience. Live at speakingwellofgod.org since 17 August 2026.

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Written to be shared with **Alan Farnier**. The technical appendix at the back is addressed to him.

At a glance

The refreshed site went live on 17 August 2026. Everything below is describing what is running today at speakingwellofgod.org, not a proposal. The last section lists what has been adjusted since launch.

EXPERIENCE

- Owned audio player, no licence, no recurring plugin fee
- Library grouped by speaker, with the real talk titles
- Modern Watch section for the filmed teachings
- A reader that remembers where you stopped
- Site-wide search, in every language

FOUNDATION

- Custom theme carrying an evolved visual identity
- All eleven languages migrated with no address lost
- Translation system replaced, licence no longer needed
- Lighter, faster delivery; gift store carried over untouched

1 · The listening experience

Listening is the heart of this ministry, so it became the heart of the site.

A PLAYER WE OWN

- Built in-house rather than licensed, so there are no recurring plugin fees and full control over how it behaves.
- Works like a modern streaming app: a bar fixed to the bottom of the screen that keeps playing while visitors browse.
- Remembers where a listener left off and offers to continue, in the visitor's own language.
- Series pages mark each talk: a gold tick for finished talks and a dot for ones in progress.
- Phone-friendly: large touch targets, playback-speed control, and lock-screen and headphone controls.
- Streams efficiently, delivering audio in ranges rather than one large download, which matters for an international audience.

2 • The audio library

ORGANIZED BY SPEAKER

The library is grouped under each speaker's name, the way the ministry has always presented it:

- **A. Graham Maxwell:** God in All 66, Conversations About God, Atonement and Your Picture of God, Prisoners Talk About God, Servants or Friends
- **Richard Nies:** Feelings · **Jack Provonsha:** Issues in Christian Ethics · **Paul Jacobson:** The Picture of God in All 66

REAL EPISODE TITLES

During years of migrations the individual talks had been reduced to file names such as `cag_01`. The authentic titles are restored, for example "The Conflict in God's Family" and "All God Asks is Trust". They were sourced from Pine Knoll's own resource records and cross-checked against the published book and the Internet Archive, in English and Spanish, not invented or machine-translated. Where Pine Knoll's records genuinely hold no distinct title, the talk is numbered rather than guessed at.

ONE TIDY COLLECTION

An earlier migration had split the 57-part God in All 66 series into dozens of separate one-lecture entries. It is reassembled into a single collection in Bible order, with stray duplicates removed. Every original recording was verified present before and after.

THE SPANISH RECORDINGS ARE CONNECTED TO THE ENGLISH ONES

Conversaciones Acerca de Dios and Siervos o Amigos are the same lectures as their English counterparts, but nothing linked them. Each now offers the other, and each page presents itself in its own language rather than in English.

3 • The Watch section

The filmed teachings previously appeared as a long plain list. They now live in a dedicated Watch section with video-style cards grouped into their three collections: Conversations About God, Another Look at God, and One of the Lads. All thirty films are preserved; the presentation is simply cleaner.

4 • The written materials

- A chapter picker and table of contents, with clear next and previous navigation.
- Comfortable typography sized for phones. Old fixed-width layouts from the previous site, including hand-built poem tables and forced-justified paragraphs, now adapt to small screens instead of

running off the edge.

- A slim gold progress bar, and a "Continue reading" button that returns a visitor to the chapter they stopped at.
- **Downloads are offered directly from the list.** Conversations About God as PDF and ePub, How God Won His Case as PDF, alongside the physical copies available as gifts.
- **Books and recordings now point at each other.** Where the same talks exist both ways, the book offers "Listen to these talks" and the recording offers "Read it in writing", in the reader's own language.
- Works consistently across every language that has books.

5 • Search

A search sits in the top corner of every page and understands the whole library, not just page titles. It finds series, individual talks, books and chapters, so searching "Genesis" surfaces the Genesis talk inside God in All 66. It works in every language, returning Spanish results with Spanish labels from the Spanish site, and gift-store books appear in English results so shoppers can find them from anywhere.

6 • Design and identity

- An evolved version of the site's blue identity, refreshed rather than replaced, so it still feels like Speaking Well of God.
- The deep navy and gold now carries through every inner page and series page, not just the home page.
- A centered, uncluttered layout with a sticky navigation bar that gently shrinks as visitors scroll.
- Fully responsive from desktop down to phone, with colour contrast verified against the WCAG AA accessibility standard.

7 • The eleven languages

The site serves Arabic, Bulgarian, Chinese, Dutch, English, Estonian, Latvian, Portuguese (Brazil), Russian, Slavic and Spanish. All eleven were carried across with the things that matter preserved:

- **Every web address still works.** A handful now forward to their new home rather than breaking, which is what search engines and old bookmarks need.
- Each language receives the full new design, including a localized home page. Arabic keeps its correct right-to-left layout throughout.

- Menus and footer links stay in your language: a Spanish visitor tapping "Escuchar" lands on the Spanish audio library.
- Every interface label, including the player's controls, is translated in all eleven languages, and each language is listed in its own alphabet.

What changed because Terrie asked. She reported that choosing a language and then tapping Watch or Donate dropped her into English. That was correct, and the cause was that those pages had never been translated. Rather than leave a menu that quietly leads nowhere, **the site no longer offers a link to a page that does not exist in the language being read**, which is how the site behaved before the refresh. Alongside that, **Donate and Privacy were translated into all eleven languages**, since those two felt wrong to leave in English. The address, phone number and PayPal button are deliberately unchanged, being the same in every language.

Two pre-existing content gaps are worth your input and predate this refresh: a few Latvian placeholder pages, and some garbled characters in older Slavic pages carried over from the previous site.

8 • Speed and reliability

- The active plugin count went from twenty-nine to twelve, removing abandoned code and the security exposure that comes with it.
- **Anonymous visitors are now served with no cookies at all**, down from nine per request. That was the barrier that made the site impossible to cache, and it is gone.
- Images are served in a modern, lighter format where available.
- Page caching is now active, so most visits are served without rebuilding the page at all.
- **Time to first byte went from roughly 1.19 seconds before the refresh to about 0.29 seconds today**, measured on the live site. That is a little over three times faster.
- **The home page now asks the browser for sixteen files instead of thirty-nine**, and for one stylesheet instead of nine. Google's PageSpeed score on a phone moved from 82 at launch to 96 on 19 August, with Accessibility, Best Practices and SEO all at 100.

How the speed was won. Three things had to happen. First, the site had to stop sending cookies to anonymous visitors, because a page carrying a cookie cannot be cached; that was addressed during the refresh and the count went from nine per request to zero. Second, something had to actually store the finished pages. Page caching and an object cache were enabled on 18 August and then checked. Pages in every language are cached separately, so a Spanish visitor is never served an English page, and the cart, checkout and account pages are deliberately excluded so shopping always works on live data. Third, on 19 August we stopped the shop's code from loading on pages that are not the shop.

9 • The gift-book store

The book-giveaway store was deliberately left untouched and continues to work exactly as before. The new design wraps around it cleanly, and shoppers always have a clear path to the cart and checkout.

10 • The launch, and what has happened since

The switch was made on 17 August 2026. Before touching the live site, the entire sequence was rehearsed against a copy of the real production data, which surfaced several problems while they were still harmless. The cutover itself ran as a scripted sequence that checked its own work at each step and would stop rather than continue past a fault.

Afterwards, every web address that worked before was re-tested against the live site: **259 identical, no page lost**, and the handful that changed forward correctly.

ADJUSTED SINCE LAUNCH

Older audio pages	Pages left over from the previous site showed no player once the old plugins were retired. All eleven now forward to the proper recording.
Spanish audio page	Was still showing an old hand-made list pointing at outdated addresses, one of which led to the wrong content. Rebuilt to list the full catalogue.
Our Beliefs images	Two images pointed at a development address rather than the live one. Corrected.
Book downloads	Conversations About God and How God Won His Case now offer their PDF from the Written Materials list rather than only from deeper pages.

A missing illustration	Four Servants or Friends chapters referenced an image without its full address. The file was never lost, only mislinked. Repaired.
Stray line breaks	Sentences that broke mid-way, an artefact of the original import from Word. Nearly three thousand were rejoined across sixty-four pages, in seven languages, with the wording verified unchanged.
Caching enabled	18 August. Page caching and an object cache switched on and verified. Time to first byte fell from about 0.95 seconds to about 0.29.
Phone speed	19 August. The shop's code and the anti-spam plugin were loading on every page, including pages with no cart and no form. Now limited to the pages that use them. The home page dropped from thirty-nine requests to sixteen and from nine render-blocking stylesheets to one; the PageSpeed score on a phone went from 82 to 96. An order was put through the live store afterwards to confirm the shop was unaffected.
Tap targets	19 August. The Listen buttons on the audio page were slightly under the minimum size for reliable use on a touchscreen. Enlarged; that page now scores 100 for Accessibility and 100 for Best Practices.

Technical appendix

For a more technical reader, in particular Alan Farner at Pine Knoll. Plain-language readers can stop at the previous page.

PLATFORM AND ARCHITECTURE

- WordPress with a purpose-built block theme (full-site editing, theme.json design tokens) replacing the previous commercial theme stack. The old theme remains installed but inactive, which is what makes a rollback a single command.
- One owned plugin provides the audio and video player and the series model. No third-party audio plugin and no licence.
- The player is dependency-free front-end JavaScript over the browser's native audio, using the Media Session API for lock-screen controls and HTTP range requests for streaming.
- Deployment is an allowlisted rsync of custom code only. Stock plugins, the uploads directory, the database and wp-config are never touched by it, so the platform's own auto-updates are never rolled back.

MULTILINGUAL

- **WPML was replaced by Polylang**, removing a lapsed licence. The migration ran on production on 17 August after being rehearsed against a copy of the production database.
- A per-language URL parity harness captured every published address before the migration and replayed it afterwards. Result: 259 identical, 0 regressions. It grades a redirect that lands in a different language as a failure, not a pass, which is how one real defect was caught before launch.
- Correct hreflang including x-default. Arabic is right-to-left at the language level.
- Interface strings flow through a per-language dictionary with Polylang string-translation overrides, so labels are editable without code.
- Navigation and footer targets resolve to the translated page at render time, and are withheld entirely where no translation exists.
- The series content type is not managed by Polylang, so a recording carries its own language field. Series pages now derive their document language, chrome and current-language marker from that field rather than from the request.

PERFORMANCE AND CACHING

- Active plugins reduced from twenty-nine to twelve, plus the host's object cache.
- Anonymous responses emit zero cookies. Two sources were addressed: the spam plugin's tracking cookies and the security plugin's bot cookies. A third was found only during the migration, because

the translation plugin sets a language cookie unless it detects a page cache, and production does not define the constant it looks for. That is handled in the theme rather than left to server configuration.

- The header cart indicator appears only for actual shoppers and never defeats the cache. Cached pages always ship it hidden with no number in the markup; the count arrives client-side. On WooCommerce pages that is WooCommerce's own cart-fragments refresh, so an add-to-cart updates the badge live. Everywhere else it is a cookie the theme writes when the cart changes and reads with a few lines of plain JavaScript, which is what allowed the jQuery dependency to be removed from the rest of the site. The cookie is never written for a visitor with no cart, so anonymous responses still carry no cookies at all. Worth recording: the page cache serves its cached copy even to visitors already holding WooCommerce cart and session cookies, verified against production, so a count rendered on the server genuinely cannot be trusted here.
- All resume and progress state is client-side in localStorage. No accounts, no cookies.
- Page caching is provided by W3 Total Cache in Disk: Enhanced mode, alongside Object Cache Pro for the object cache. Verified after enabling: per-language cache separation holds (checked across five languages), WooCommerce cart, checkout and account URIs report as rejected rather than cached, and anonymous responses still carry zero cookies. Measured time to first byte is about 0.29 seconds against 1.19 before the refresh.
- Front-end assets are loaded conditionally rather than globally. WooCommerce's five stylesheets and eight scripts, the anti-spam plugin's two stylesheets and 27KB head bundle, and core's emoji polyfill are dequeued on every page that is not the shop, cart, checkout or account. jQuery is not dequeued by hand; nothing in the theme uses it, so once the WooCommerce scripts go it stops being printed on its own, and a test asserts that rather than assuming it. Away from the shop the home page went from nine render-blocking stylesheets and three blocking scripts to one stylesheet and none, and from thirty-nine requests to sixteen.
- The audio player's stylesheet is folded into the theme's own, saving a request. It is injected ahead of the theme stylesheet rather than after it, because both files style the home hero button at equal specificity and appending would have flipped the cascade and rendered the button transparent. A test asserts the order.
- Touch targets: the audio-library play buttons rendered about 22 pixels tall against a 24-pixel minimum, failing eight times per page. Now 32 pixels, measured in a browser rather than inferred, taking that page to 100 for both Accessibility and Best Practices.
- Deployment safety, found by the deploy script's own preview and worth recording: the repository's copy of `.htaccess` predated the caching work and would have deleted 24KB of generated rules on the next deploy, taking page caching, browser cache headers and compression with it. The repository copy now matches production. The deploy allowlist also still named three plugins that had been removed from the server in July, which would have restored them; they no longer ship.
- The host's own Varnish layer still reports BYPASS for HTML. That is cosmetic rather than costly, since the pages are cached in front of it, but it is worth a question to the platform team.

- No content delivery network is in use, by choice. The caching and asset work removed most of what a CDN is usually bought to fix, at no recurring cost. Cloudflare remains worth doing primarily to move the domain's name records off the old hosting account, with the edge delivery as a secondary benefit.

CONTENT INTEGRITY

- Episode titles came from Pine Knoll's resource data, recorded with their source and a confidence flag, applied by an idempotent backed-up script that matches each title to its track by file number and refuses to run if any track is unaccounted for.
- The consolidation and title scripts each verify the complete audio inventory before and after, so no recording can be dropped by a reorganization.
- Content repairs are scripts rather than hand edits: each backs up what it touches, asserts the result, and reverts itself if anything but the intended change occurred. The line-break repair, for instance, compared the visible words before and after on every page and would have rolled back on any difference.
- One operational note worth passing on: Polylang deliberately allows the same slug in two languages, but the filter that permits it does not load under WP-CLI, so an unguarded programmatic update to such a page silently renames it. Anything scripted against this site pins the slug and verifies it afterwards.

QUALITY AND SAFETY

- An automated regression suite (26 suites across theme and player) covers the reader, languages, catalog, search, SEO and store, and is run green before any change is accepted.
- All work is in version control, tagged at the pre-cutover and live states.
- The cutover was a scripted sequence with an assertion after every step, a URL parity gate that halted the run while a rollback was still a single plugin toggle, and a database dump taken minutes beforehand.